

Rajeev Satav, the 37-year-old IYC chief, says, "The amount of time I save, because I don't have senior leaders calling me to promote someone, is amazing." Or as Union Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Jitin Prasada eloquently puts it, "The era of the three Cs—*chamchas*, *chaploos* and *chelas* (networkers and hangers-on) is over." The playing field has suddenly been levelled. Moreover,

with Rahul in charge, the organisation which had lapsed into lethargy and oblivion suddenly has both a purpose and a poster boy. It also holds the hottest ticket to the future.

Addressing a youth rally in Tamil Nadu recently, Rahul said, "We are going to develop the future leadership of the state in this organisation." This is his plan: to create a grooming ground that will develop the kind of

leaders he wants for the future. This is a strategy that both his father Rajiv and uncle Sanjay believed in—using the youth wing to build their own team. Manmohan Singh's Cabinet today has as many as 12 alumni from the Sanjay-Rajiv era of the IYC, four of these being former IYC national presidents. Rahul once told his team, "The youth came to the party in a big way in 1977 and 1980s, not so much in the 1990s." Both Sanjay and Rajiv had harnessed youth power successfully to implement the Congress' policies in the '70s and '80s. During the last general elections, Rahul ensured that 10 of his IYC candidates were given tickets. Eight of these won. The building blocks are slowly being put in place. The idea is to both identify and cultivate new talents as electoral assets.

Rahul has also realised that unlike the BJP or Left, the Congress lacked a cadre that was committed to the organisation. What it had instead were little factions owing allegiance to an individual simply because the system encouraged such patronage.

Punjab was the first state to hold elections last year. The joke within the Congress was that if Rahul succeeded in holding elections in the faction-ridden Punjab, he would succeed anywhere. Since then, Gujarat (7,50,000 members), Daman and Diu (6,274 members) and Puducherry (67,848 members) have held elections while the process is underway in Bihar, Rajasthan, Haryana and Tamil Nadu. "I'm not empowering the youth, the IYC is empowering them. I'm just a catalyst," he once said, adding with a smile, "I'm not even a member of the IYC."

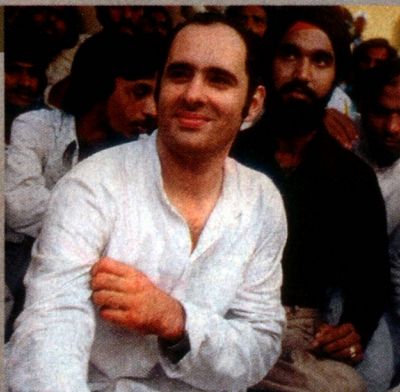
Ironically, Punjab elections ended up electing another young dynast, Beant Singh's grandson Ravneet Singh Bittu. But the drive also recruited three-and-a-half lakh members as opposed to the earlier score of 30,000. "Yes Bittuji is related to an ex-chief minister. But what is the reality? If we have to run a democratic organisation, we cannot turn someone away just because he is son of some politician. Democracy is an idea and it will take time for it to run smoothly,"

Catching them Young

Sanjay and Rajiv Gandhi used the Youth Congress as a grooming ground for young leadership. Now Rahul wants to do the same.

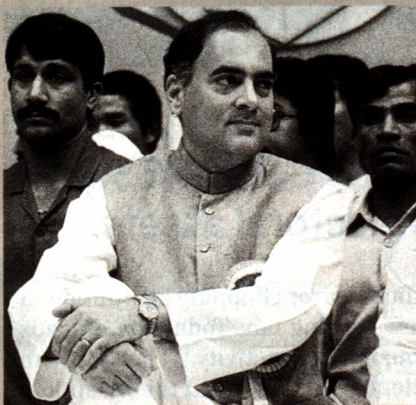
SANJAY GANDHI

The organisation peaked during 1976 to 1981 under him. With its agitational and social programmes, it became the backbone of Indira's Congress, particularly during the Emergency. Cabinet ministers such as Ambika Soni, Kamal Nath and Ghulam Nabi Azad were part of Sanjay's brigade.



RAJIV GANDHI

After Sanjay's death, Rajiv took over the youth wing. As prime minister, he reduced the voting age to 18. He used the youth wing to counter V.P. Singh's Mandal agenda. Three current Union ministers—Mukul Wasnik, Anand Sharma and Gurudas Kamat—were national Youth Congress chiefs in his era.



RAHUL GANDHI

When Rahul took over as party general secretary in 2007, the youth wing was a bunch of brash, aimless, not-so-young men. In three years, he has changed all that. Elections have been held in five states and his deadline for the revamp is December 2010 when for the first time since 1971, the IYC will have an elected national president.